to the IMF's first-ever international bond issue in 2009, thus becoming a creditor of the IMF (see Chapter 3). Within the Bretton Woods institutions, Brazilian economic policymakers have deployed sufficient power resources to secure flexibility for Brazil itself on issues considered to be of overriding importance, but they have lacked the means to reform the overall agenda or rules permanently. Through the BRICS, Brazil now can pursue both inside reforms and outside options.

Domestic Politics

Shorter-term political and economic challenges provided additional incentives for the governments of presidents da Silva and Rousseff to participate actively in the BRICS club. These leaders from the Workers' Party (PT) needed to be able to claim to their core supporters that they had not deserted their once-fiery Marxist ideals, despite the daily compromises imposed by the practicalities of governing in a large, federal, presidential democracy, including continuation of the centrist macroeconomic policies of former President Cardoso.[244] Although its practice of forging links with other developing countries and emerging powers was already in place, Brazil increased its ambitious foreign policy rhetoric after 2003, emphasizing antihegemonic solidarity among countries of the global South, which is both a geographic and an ideological category.

Due to the political benefits to the PT leaders from being seen (mainly within Brazil) to oppose an overbearing United States, Brazilian government positions on the specifics of BRICS financial statecraft have not always been fully coherent, particularly with respect to currency issues and international monetary statecraft. In general, Brazil, along with India, was happy to endorse the collective goal of reducing U.S. dollar hegemony in the world. Thus, the statement of the BRICS at its very first summit in Yekaterinburg, Russia, of its support for a "new global money," leading to a smaller reserve currency role for the U.S. dollar was favorably commented on within Brazil. Finance Minister Mantega, who served under two da Silva administrations and the first Rousseff administration, became well known globally for his declaration of September 2010 that the world, but mainly the United States and China, was engaged in a "currency war."

Mantega was probably the senior figure among the BRICS who was most ready to envision a larger international role for China and the RMB as the best way to counter the pernicious and hegemonic influence of the United